

How to Deal With an Angry Person Without Making Things Worse

Have you ever tried to calm someone down, only to realize that everything you say seems to make them even angrier?

You tell them to calm down.

They get louder.

You explain why they're wrong.

They become more defensive.

You try to defend yourself.

Now you're both angry.

This is one of the most difficult situations in relationships, families, workplaces, and classrooms. When another person is overwhelmed by anger, our instinct is often to fight back, defend ourselves, or prove our point.

But what if those reactions are exactly what makes the situation worse?

Emotional intelligence offers another possibility: instead of responding to anger with more anger, we can sometimes change the emotional direction of the interaction.

Don't Fight Emotion With Emotion

When someone is extremely angry, logic doesn't always work immediately.

You may have a perfectly reasonable explanation. You may even be completely right about the facts.

But if the other person is emotionally overwhelmed, giving them more information may not solve the problem.

They may not be ready to listen.

And if you respond to their anger with your own anger, the situation can quickly become a competition over who can shout louder or defend themselves more aggressively.

This doesn't mean that you should tolerate abusive or threatening behavior. If someone is becoming violent or you feel unsafe, creating distance and getting appropriate help is more important than trying to demonstrate emotional intelligence.

But when the situation is safe enough to engage, there is another question worth asking:

What is actually happening underneath this person's anger?

Anger May Be Covering Something Else

Anger is sometimes the most visible part of a much more complicated emotional experience.

Someone may be angry because they feel disrespected.

They may be embarrassed.

They may feel rejected.

They may be frightened.

They may feel powerless.

They may be grieving.

They may simply feel that nobody is listening to them.

Understanding this does not mean agreeing with their behavior.

It means trying to understand the person behind the behavior.

That distinction can completely change the way we approach a difficult conversation.

A Powerful Example From Daniel Goleman's *Emotional Intelligence*

There is a remarkable story in Daniel Goleman's book *Emotional Intelligence: Why It Can Matter More Than IQ* that illustrates this idea.

Goleman recounts a story told by Terry Dobson, an American who studied the martial art aikido in Japan.

One day, Dobson was riding a train in suburban Tokyo when a large, heavily intoxicated man began terrorizing the passengers.

The man was shouting, threatening people, and behaving violently.

Dobson was physically capable of confronting him. He had extensive aikido training and was prepared to intervene if necessary.

But he remembered something his teacher had taught him: the purpose of aikido was not simply to defeat an opponent. It was to resolve conflict rather than create it.

Before Dobson could act, however, an elderly Japanese man sitting elsewhere on the train called to the drunk man.

Instead of confronting him, the old man spoke to him warmly.

He asked what he had been drinking.

“Sake,” the man answered.

The old man enthusiastically told him that he also enjoyed sake. He began talking about drinking it with his wife in their garden and about the persimmon tree in his backyard.

Something changed.

The drunk man's aggression began to disappear.

His fists relaxed.

His voice became quieter.

And eventually, he began talking about his own life.

His wife had died.

He had lost his home.

He had lost his job.

He was ashamed of what had happened to him.

The man who had appeared to be nothing more than an aggressive drunk was carrying enormous pain.

The elderly man had not defeated him.

He had changed the emotional direction of the encounter.

Goleman presents this as an example of exceptional emotional skill.

What Can We Learn From This?

The story does not provide a magic formula for calming angry people.

There isn't one.

Different people become angry for different reasons, and sometimes there is no productive conversation to be had in the moment.

But the story illustrates several principles that can be useful when dealing with anger.

1. Don't automatically match the other person's emotional intensity

If someone raises their voice and you immediately raise yours, the emotional temperature usually increases.

Remaining calm doesn't guarantee that the other person will calm down, but it prevents you from contributing additional emotional fuel.

2. Listen before trying to solve the problem

When someone is angry, our first instinct may be to explain ourselves.

But sometimes the person needs to feel heard before they can hear us.

Listening doesn't mean agreeing.

It means giving yourself an opportunity to understand what the person is actually upset about.

3. Look beneath the anger

Ask yourself:

“What could this person be experiencing right now?”

Perhaps they feel ignored.

Perhaps they are frightened.

Perhaps something happened earlier that you don't know about.

Perhaps the current argument isn't really about the thing you're arguing about.

You may not always get the answer right, but asking the question changes your perspective.

4. Change the direction of the conversation

Sometimes continuing to argue about the same point simply keeps the conflict alive.

A genuine question, a moment of empathy, or a shift toward a more constructive subject can interrupt that cycle.

The objective isn't to manipulate the person.

It is to create an opportunity for both people to leave the emotional reaction and return to a more thoughtful conversation.

What About Angry Children?

This becomes particularly important for parents and teachers.

Children don't always have the vocabulary or emotional maturity to explain what they are experiencing.

A child may shout because they are frustrated.

They may refuse to participate because they are afraid of failing.

They may become aggressive because they feel embarrassed.

They may have a meltdown because they are overwhelmed.

If an adult responds only to the behavior, they may miss the emotion underneath it.

That doesn't mean there should be no boundaries.

Quite the opposite.

Children need clear boundaries.

A useful response might be:

“I understand that you're angry. But you cannot hit anyone. Let's talk about what happened when you're ready.”

The adult is doing two things simultaneously.

They are setting a boundary around unacceptable behavior while acknowledging the child's emotional experience.

That is an important distinction.

A child can learn:

“My feelings are valid, but my feelings do not give me permission to hurt other people.”

That lesson can remain valuable throughout adulthood.

What If the Other Person Won't Calm Down?

Sometimes nothing works.

A person may not want to listen.

They may continue shouting.

They may be intoxicated.

They may be deliberately trying to intimidate you.

They may be experiencing a level of emotional distress that makes rational conversation impossible.

In these situations, emotional intelligence also means knowing your limits.

You don't have to win every argument.

You don't have to convince everyone.

And you don't have to remain in an unsafe situation simply because you want to be understanding.

Sometimes the emotionally intelligent response is to say:

“We're both too upset to have a productive conversation right now. Let's talk later.”

Then walk away if it is safe to do so.

Emotional Intelligence Isn't About Being Passive

This is perhaps the most important point.

Being emotionally intelligent does not mean being endlessly patient.

It doesn't mean allowing people to walk over you.

It doesn't mean hiding your own anger.

And it doesn't mean accepting disrespect in the name of empathy.

Emotional intelligence is not the absence of boundaries.

It is the ability to recognize emotions—including your own—and make deliberate choices about how you respond to them.

You can be firm without being cruel.

You can disagree without becoming hostile.

You can acknowledge someone's feelings without agreeing with their conclusions.

And you can walk away from a conflict without feeling that you have lost.

The Question to Ask Yourself

The next time someone becomes extremely angry with you, try pausing before reacting.

Instead of immediately asking:

“How do I prove that I'm right?”

ask:

“What is happening here?”

What are they feeling?

What am I feeling?

What is actually causing the conflict?

Is this the right time to solve the problem?

Would listening help?

Would giving the conversation some space help?

And most importantly:

“What response is most likely to make this situation better rather than worse?”

You won't always get it right.

Neither will anyone else.

Emotional intelligence isn't about having perfect control over every situation. It is a skill that develops through experience, reflection, and practice.

The remarkable train story in Goleman's *Emotional Intelligence* reminds us of something simple but easy to forget:

Sometimes the strongest response to anger isn't greater force.

It is the ability to remain sufficiently calm and curious to see the human being underneath the emotion.

And sometimes, that is where the possibility of change begins.